

arrival before they are allowed to start practising to ensure their readiness. "Often, we have to resist the temptation to over-train in short camps, yet, on occasion, also have to remind them that they might be behind on their training at times. Ironically, under-training occurs more frequently than over-training during the IPL," Leipus explains.

It all comes down to the coordination between the bowling coach and the physiotherapist. "It's a combined effort. Having a good relationship with the coaching staff – understanding their expectations and how much they need the bowler to bowl – is vital.

We might say a bowler needs to bowl four overs in training, but the coach may want him to bowl eight to perfect his skills – say, yorkers. That's a potential source of trouble," Gloster says.

Prepare for the long haul

Post his breakdown in Sydney, Bumrah missed the ICC Champions Trophy 2025 and the initial four matches of IPL 2025 for the Mumbai Indians. Despite being named the vice-captain of India during the recent Australia tour and stand-in captain of the final Test, Bumrah's injury woes have forced selectors to not burden him with more responsibility for the upcoming England tour. "We need him more as a player. We would rather have him bowling than putting extra pressure on him," India's chief selector Ajit Agarkar said during a recent press conference.

He also confirmed that Bumrah won't be playing all five Tests owing to workload management. "I don't think Bumrah will play all five Tests – whether it's four or three – we'll see how the series goes."

Bumrah's – or rather any fast bowler's – case study is a cautionary blueprint. It's a team's responsibility to treat workload like a Test match: plan for the long haul, don't burn out talent early.

Pont puts it perfectly: "It is about protecting the bowler from the game, not protecting the game from the bowler."

Major Indian pacers with back injuries	Latest year of back issue	Age during back issue
Jasprit Bumrah	2025	31
Mayank Yadav	2025	22
Hardik Pandya	2019	26
Prasidh Krishna	2022	26
Ishant Sharma	2024	36
Deepak Chahar	2022	30
Kamlesh Nagarkoti	2023	24
Shivam Mavi	2023	25

Jasprit Bumrah's workload in last three Test series				
Opposition	Venue	Date	Bumrah Balls bowled	Avg BB other pacers
Bangladesh	Chennai	19-23 Sep 2024	126	140
Bangladesh	Kanpur	27 Sep-1 Oct 2024	168	81
New Zealand	Bengaluru	16-20 Oct 2024	162	175
New Zealand	Pune	24-28 Oct 2024	84	36
Australia	Perth	22-26 Nov 2024	180	164
Australia	Adelaide	6-10 Dec 2024	144	110
Australia	Brisbane	14-18 Dec 2024	204	115
Australia	Melbourne	26-30 Dec 2024	320	204
Australia	Sydney**	3-7 Jan 2025	60	146
** Bumrah left the field after bowling 10 overs in first innings				



Workload management: Ian Pont, founder of the UK's National Fast Bowling Academy, stresses the need to track every ball a pacer bowls — in matches and training — to manage workload smartly. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY